The Times of Harvey Milk explores Harvey Milk's experience as the first openly gay elected official in California and, in doing so, shows how gay political identity developed in the 1970s to achieve institutional power. The documentary showcases how Milk became a member of the San Francisco Board of Supervisors, both as an individual and as a leading figure of an emerging gay rights movement. By looking at the analysis of the gay and lesbian political movements, this documentary can be understood in the broader context of queer politics, as the movement created coalitions and developed media strategies to enter political institutions. The Times of Harvey Milk frames Harvey Milk's political success as a result of developing an organized electoral constituency through coalition building and strategic media use, illustrating how the gay movement institutionalized power in local politics in the 1970s.

The documentary highlights Milk as a central figure in transforming a neighborhood's identity into an electoral bloc and a broad coalition. Before even being elected into office, Milk established himself as a local activist and became known as the "Mayor of Castro Street". He gathered small business owners, residents, and activists at his storefront, organizing boycotts and community initiatives. His early runs for office, although unsuccessful, built visibility and experience, creating campaign infrastructure, training volunteers, expanding networks, and normalizing the concept of a gay candidate seeking local office. In his campaigning efforts, the documentary shows how Milk did not want to be seen as just a gay representative but a representative for all people within his district. Milk's engagement with his city, beyond just gay communities, helped him eventually lead a broad coalition and achieve political success as the first openly gay elected official in California.

The concentration of support alone did not produce political power. Proctor (2022) argues that constituencies are not waiting to be represented; instead, they are activated through

“constitutive group mobilization”, where activists and party actors define who belongs to the group, what its interests are, and how it aligns with existing institutions. The documentary shows that this was the exact mechanism Milk used. He did not run solely as a gay candidate, instead tying in other community issues like labor rights, tenant protections, and minority protections. One example is that during Milk’s campaign he supported local unions by successfully organizing the Coors boycott in the gay bars in San Francisco. This move linked gay communities with organized labor movements, embedding gay politics within a larger progressive movement. This consolidation of issues reflected the broader electoral strategy of lesbian and gay activists and political actors, which was to consolidate gay rights by linking them to other marginalized groups and framing them within a broader civil rights coalition (Proctor 2022). Milk’s campaign took an existing community that he was a part of and linked it with the broader district community to create an electorate capable of victory.

Armstrong's account of the movement in San Francisco further helps to explain why Milk’s strategies worked. Armstrong argues that by the late 1970s, the movement that Milk helped develop was culturally vibrant and politically powerful. The documentary highlights how Milk institutionalized the gay political identity through local elections, grassroots campaigns, and most importantly, coalition building. Here, institutionalization refers to embedding gay political claims within formal governance structures beyond just winning office, opening avenues for policy change. By the time of the Briggs initiative, the movement was mature, having already shown its political muscle by electing Milk to office and demonstrating its overall strength in defeating Proposition 6 (Armstrong 2002). Milk’s successes were possible because over the course of a decade he created a new political coalition.

The documentary highlights that part of Harvey Milk's political strategy was not only developing his coalition but also gaining visibility. Milk's campaign events, presence at gay marches, and press interactions forced public recognition of the gay community. In contrast to earlier activists who were reluctant to publicly mobilize, this era of strategy focused on open visibility (Proctor 2022). Milk furthered this open visibility by insisting that gay people must "come out". This was not a personal recommendation but a political strategy to change the perceived size and normalcy of the gay and lesbian community, countering fear-based perceptions of the community.

At the same time, Milk understood that this visibility had to be tailored carefully to ensure maximum reach across different political ideologies. The documentary highlights Milk's understanding of media appearances. One interview highlights that in his preparation for the debate on the Briggs Initiative and Briggs himself, he described the need to dress as conservatively and normally as possible. His goal was to represent the gay and lesbian community as reasonable and normal to give legitimacy to the campaign against Prop 6. Armstrong and Crage (2006) identify this strategy as part of the early moderate homophile approach, where activists distanced themselves from radical presentations instead favoring assimilation.

While the documentary presents Milk's institutional approach as necessary and effective, it sidelines the tensions and exclusions in respectability-driven politics. Cohen's analysis of boundary-making within marginalized communities provides a framework for understanding the limits of the respectability strategy. Cohen (1999) argues that movements seeking political recognition try to control the presentation of their group, elevating those who they deem respectable and distancing those who threaten legitimacy. This mechanism can apply to Milk's

strategy, as he tried to enter political institutions by conforming to dominant norms. The documentary shows that Milk's public image was deliberate, presenting himself as a reasonably respectable member of society by heterosexual norms to counter conservative fears of deviancy. While his movement represented gender nonconforming individuals and people of color, it did not center them as part of its political image.

The pursuit of electoral viability elevates those who can assimilate into dominant hierarchies, while sidelining those who are more marginalized. This documentary celebrates Milk's strategy to appear normal, but does not fully examine what forms of queerness were suppressed or excluded from that movement. This reveals the tradeoffs inherent in institutional politics, as coalition building and media strategy expanded gay political power but also required strategic boundary management. Cohen's analysis emphasizes these tradeoffs as incorporation into governance simultaneously advances rights and reproduces exclusions. The documentary showcases the gains of institutionalization, but further analysis of the movements of the time shows that political power is structured by the dominant hierarchies of our society.

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